CHIPKO MOVEMENT

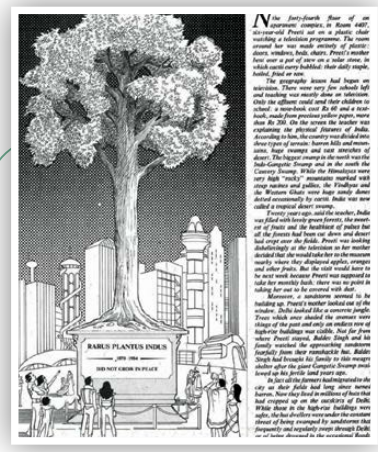
THE GREEN SAVIOURS

The simple, collective act of hugging trees saved the remaining forests in the Himalayas and serves as a beacon to both policy-making and environmental activism in India and beyond

BY JUMANA SHAH

Can the dead weight of a bureaucratic decision be worn down by the homespun tactics of villagers led by women? The Chipko Andolan, one of the most significant environmental movements in India, showed that it can. It crystallised in the villages of Chamoli tehsil of Uttarakhand's Garhwal region (then in Uttar Pradesh) in the early 1970s, and was mounted against rapid deforestation that took an axe to livelihoods through its deleterious side-effects—flooding, landslides and depletion of water sources. The immediate spark: the (then) UP government's auctioning of 2,500 trees in the region for commercial felling. When the loggers approached Reni village in March 1974, Gaura Devi and other women embraced the trees earmarked for felling and told the loggers their axes will have to pass through them first. Earlier, in 1973, women in nearby Mandal village had similarly confronted loggers and stood their ground for days. Tales of their resistance spread and inspired other villagers to join in. The guiding spirit of the Chipko Movement was the Gandhian ecologist Chandi Prasad Bhatt and his Dasholi Gram Swarajya Mandal. As the movement gathered ground, the government gave ground.

The startlingly poignant act of hugging trees was seen as a powerful and nonviolent response to save the Himalayan forests. Between 1980 and 1983, Gandhian activist Sunderlal Bahuguna walked 5,000 km in the Himalayan foothills, spreading the philosophy of the Chipko movement—of living in harmony with nature. As



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Forests **Plunder Blunder**

In Chamoli, it is the women who are the main force of the Chipko movement. The burden of gathering firewood falls on them. Said 65-year-old Paravati Devi, her face lined with toil and age: "It takes me at least the whole day to collect firewood. We must preserve our trees."

–Raj Chengappa

